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200,000 return to north Gaza in 2 hours

CROSSING ALLOWED AFTER ISRAEL AND HAMAS REACH DEAL FOR RELEASE OF 6 MORE HOSTAGES

NUSEIRAT

Masses of displaced Palestinians began streaming towards the north of the war-battered Gaza Strip yesterday after Israel and Hamas said they had reached a deal for the release of another six hostages.

The breakthrough preserves a fragile ceasefire and paves the way for more hostage-prisoner swaps under an agreement aimed at ending the more than 15-month conflict, which has devastated the Gaza Strip and displaced nearly all its residents.

Israel had been preventing Palestinians from returning to their homes in northern Gaza, accusing Hamas of violating the terms of the truce, but Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's office said late Sunday they would be allowed to pass after the new deal was reached.

Homeward bound

Crowds began making their way north along a coastal road on foot yesterday morning, carrying what belongings they could, AFP TV images showed.

A Gaza security official told AFP that "more than 200,000 displaced people have returned to Gaza and North Gaza governorates in the first two hours".

He said that authorities were still waiting for the green light to allow the displaced to cross in their vehicles via Salah Al



■ Displaced Gazans cross the Netzarim corridor from the southern Gaza Strip into Gaza City yesterday. Hamas said the return of Gazans to the north of the devastated territory was a victory against 'plans' for forced displacement of Palestinians.

Din road, Gaza's main passageway between the north and south.

"It's a great feeling when you go back home, back to your family, relatives and loved ones, and inspect your house — if it is still a house," displaced Gazan

Ebrahim Abu Hassera told AFP. Hamas called the return "a victory" for Palestinians that "signals the failure and defeat of the plans for occupation and displacement".

Its ally Islamic Jihad, meanwhile, called it a "response to

all those who dream of displacing our people".

The comments came after US President Donald Trump floated an idea to "clean out" Gaza and resettle Palestinians in Jordan and Egypt, drawing condemnation from regional leaders. Presi-

dent Mahmud Abbas, whose Palestinian Authority is based in the Israeli-occupied West Bank, issued a "strong rejection and condemnation of any projects" aimed at displacing Palestinians from Gaza, his office said. —AFP

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2025 declared Year of Community in UAE

ABU DHABI
Gulf News Report

President His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Zayed Al Nahyan yesterday announced that 2025 will be observed as the Year of Community in the UAE.

Taking to X, he said, "I am pleased to announce 2025 as the Year of Community in the UAE. Hand in hand, we will work to strengthen social bonds, foster shared responsibility and unlock potential for inclusive and sustainable growth. To all those who call UAE home, I encourage you to think ambitiously and act boldly in contributing towards improving your community and ensuring that our nation remains an inspiring model of progress and prosperity," he wrote.

In a separate tweet, His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, said, "The declaration of 2025 as the Year of the Community highlights our priorities for the future: Strengthening social bonds and fostering unity across society."

He said, "The foundation of our nation's strength lies in a united community where individuals are connected and care is extended to each other."

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